ENGLISH LAB · READING CORNER

Lantern Night

An old lantern. A lost tradition. A secret waiting to be told.



Plus · B1+

4 ESO · Seasons & Celebrations · LS2
Six chapters · one a week

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How to read this book

Read one chapter a week at home, with the Learning Path it goes with. Read it once for the story, then again more slowly.

The words in the box at the start help you. They are underlined in the story.

At the end of each chapter, circle one answer to each question. In class we talk about the chapter for ten minutes and see who guessed what happens next.

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CHAPTER 1

The lantern in the attic

Read it with Learning Path 0

WORDS TO HELP YOU

faded = *descolorit*
attic = *golfes*
lantern = *fanalet*
ink = *tinta*
shake = *tremolar*

When Núria Puig arrived in Ashby on Saturday 24 October, the first thing she noticed was the weather. The sky was grey, the station was wet, and Josh Green stood under a very small umbrella. “Welcome to the north of England,” he said. “Please enjoy the rain. It’s always here.”

“I brought a jacket,” Núria replied, “but I didn’t bring a boat.” They knew each other through months of online chats, but this was their first meeting in person.

Núria was fifteen and spent the rest of the autumn term with Josh’s family. Her new routine was different: school started earlier than at home, the family ate dinner at six, and the clocks went back on her first weekend. “Dinner at six?” she asked Josh’s mum, Helen.

“In Catalonia we usually eat at nine.”

“Here you’ll have time for another dinner at nine,” Josh joked.

Helen lived with Josh, his younger sister Amy and their grandmother Margaret, who was always called Gran.

Gran spent much of her time in the garden, even in chilly weather. She was friendly, but often seemed to be thinking about something else. At four each afternoon, she made a cup of tea and sat quietly by the window. Núria noticed other small differences too. At school she had a light lunch, then the Greens ate their main meal before the evening was really dark.

Josh usually went out with friends after school, while Gran stayed in and took care of the garden. Her new habits were not better than her rou-

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tine in Catalonia; they were just different. She wrote to her family that the exchange helped her understand another way of life, even if she still wanted a late dinner and more sun. On Halloween, Amy dressed up as a witch. Josh carved a pumpkin, with a face that looked more tired than scary.

Núria told everyone about the Castanyada, which is celebrated in Catalonia at the same time of year. “We roast chestnuts and sweet potatoes, and we eat panellets,” she explained. “Both celebrations bring families together, but they’re quite different.”

“Can a chestnut be a costume?” Amy asked.

“With some good ideas, yes.” Helen suggested making panellets the next day. “There should be some things for cooking panellets in the attic.”

After dinner, Josh and Núria went upstairs.

The attic had old paper and many boxes: Christmas decorations, old toys, a broken lamp and some old books. Josh looked for cooking things when Núria noticed a red and gold paper lantern under the window. Its colours were faded, but it was carefully made. “This is beautiful,” she said.

“Look, there’s writing on it.” In black ink, someone wrote: “M. — Lantern Night, at the old bridge. I’ll wait for you. T.”

“What’s Lantern Night?” Núria asked.

Josh looked at the lantern. “I grew up here, but I don’t know it. Let’s ask Gran. She knows the town’s history.”

They brought it downstairs. Gran had her usual tea. She smiled when she saw them, but the smile disappeared as soon as she noticed the lantern. “Where did you get that?” she asked quietly.

“In the attic,” Josh said. “Who’s M? And who’s T?”

For several seconds Gran didn’t move. Then her hands began to shake. She placed her cup on the table and stood up. “Please put that lantern back,” she said.

Her voice was quiet, but her face wasn’t. She left the room before either teenager could ask another question.

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"I think we found something important," Núria said.

"Important?" Josh replied.

"My gran has just walked away from a cup of tea. That's never happened before."

They looked at the lantern again. Someone waited at the old bridge, and Gran knew why.

THINK ABOUT IT

Circle one answer for each question.

1 · DID YOU UNDERSTAND?

What makes Gran upset?

- (A) An old lantern with a message
- (B) A pumpkin costume
- (C) Núria's homework

2 · WHAT HAPPENS NEXT? GUESS!

What do Josh and Núria find at the library?

- (A) An old phone
- (B) A poster for Lantern Night in 1974
- (C) A letter from Canada dated today

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CHAPTER 2

A poster from 1974

Read it with Learning Path 1

WORDS TO HELP YOU

yellowing = *groguenc*
harvest = *collita*
died out = *va desaparèixer*
council = *ajuntament*
kept in touch = *van mantenir el contacte*

Gran didn't appear at breakfast the following morning. This was strange: she normally made tea before anybody else came downstairs. Josh and Núria looked at each other, both worried and curious. "We shouldn't make her sad again," Núria said. "But the lantern must have a history."

"If anyone knows that history, it's Mrs Okafor," Josh replied. "She works in the library and remembers every important event in this town."

The community centre stood beside the town square, where people put up autumn decorations.

Inside, Mrs Okafor put up pictures about local traditions. When she saw the red and gold lantern, she stopped immediately. "Now that's something I haven't seen for years!" she said.

"Where did you find it?" Josh explained.

Mrs Okafor led them into a room where the library kept old posters, photographs and newspaper reports. She carefully opened a large book of old papers and showed them a yellowing poster. "ASHBY LANTERN NIGHT — SATURDAY 16 NOVEMBER 1974 — PARADE FROM THE TOWN SQUARE TO THE OLD BRIDGE — LIVE MUSIC, HOT FOOD — BRING YOUR LANTERN!"

"I don't remember any festival like this," Josh said.

"That's because it died out long before you were born," Mrs Okafor explained. "Lantern Night used to bring the whole community together. The

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tradition started more than 100 years ago, at harvest time. Families made paper lanterns and gathered in the square. They walked through the town to the bridge, where they lit candles and made wishes."

"So it wasn't only a party," Núria said. "It was a way to keep the community together."

"Exactly. Some customs change, but the reason people celebrate often stays the same."

Núria told her about the Castanyada, which is celebrated in Catalonia on the same autumn weekend as Halloween. She explained that families share chestnuts, sweet potatoes and panellets.

They also talked about Diwali, when people light diyas, and the Lantern Festival in China.

"Those traditions have different histories and ideas," Mrs Okafor said, "but light can bring people together in many places. We shouldn't say they're all the same." Mrs Okafor also explained that some old celebrations continued because schools, families and local groups made an effort to keep them alive. "A tradition isn't just something in a museum," she said.

"People need to take part in it." Núria thought about that as they looked at the poster.

Josh pointed at the date on the poster. "What happened in 1974? Why was that the last year?"

Mrs Okafor searched through her notes. "There was a terrible storm on the festival day. The old bridge was damaged by the wind, and the parade was cancelled. The council closed the bridge. No one managed to organise the festival the following year. The person who used to do most of the work left Ashby just a week after the storm."

"Who was that?" Núria asked.

"A young man called Tom Barker. He was twenty-one, and he moved to Canada for a job."

"That's a very long way to go," Josh said.

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Mrs Okafor agreed. “In those days, there were no quick messages or video calls. People wrote letters. Some kept in touch, and others stopped writing to each other.”

Núria looked at the red lantern in her hands.

The message on its side was short, but suddenly it seemed much more important. “M. — Lantern Night, at the old bridge. I’ll wait for you. T.”

“T is Tom,” she said. “The storm stopped the parade, and he left the next week.”

Josh looked worried. “Then who is M? And why does Gran know about it?”

Mrs Okafor put the poster back in the book. “I think you have one more piece of history to discover. Just make sure you check the facts, not only the stories people tell.”

As they left the library, Núria saw that the real mystery wasn’t the festival. It was the person who planned to wait at the bridge.

THINK ABOUT IT

Circle one answer for each question.

1 · DID YOU UNDERSTAND?

What did people do at Lantern Night?

- (A) They held a parade to the old bridge
- (B) They went on a school trip to London
- (C) They played a football match

2 · WHAT HAPPENS NEXT? GUESS!

Who is M on the lantern?

- (A) Mrs Okafor
- (B) Amy
- (C) Gran, whose name was Margaret Hall

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CHAPTER 3

Who is M?

Read it with Learning Paths 2 and 3

WORDS TO HELP YOU

anonymous = *anònim*
evidence = *proves*
caption = *peu de foto*
references = *referències*
permission = *permís*

That evening, Josh and Núria decided to research the history of Lantern Night carefully. The red and gold lantern sat between them on the kitchen table, and Josh's laptop showed a long list of search results.

"Let's not believe the first surprising story we see," Núria said. "We need a good source. Who wrote it? When was it written? What facts show it?"

"You're turning our kitchen into a research centre," Josh joked. "Exactly. Now find the facts."

Their first result was a website called Ashby Memories. A user with no name said Lantern Night stopped because two families were angry about money. The post had no date, and there were no references.

"It might be true," Josh said. "Maybe, but we can't say it's a fact. There's no evidence."

Next they opened a social media page full of old photographs. One showed families carrying lanterns over the bridge.

It was a beautiful photo, but nobody gave the photographer's name or a date.

"So we can describe what we see," Núria said, "but we can't say when it happened."

Then they found the online archive of the local newspaper, the Ashby Herald. This time, the article had a clear date, 17 November 1974, and the journalist's name. Its title read: "STORM CLOSES OLD BRIDGE." The report

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explained that Lantern Night was cancelled the night before because strong winds damaged the bridge.

The council closed it to keep people safe. The article also talked about Tom Barker, the twenty-one-year-old organiser who planned to move to Canada the following week.

“This is the same as what Mrs Okafor told us,” Josh said.

“That’s good news.” Núria agreed. “It doesn’t show every part of the story, but now we have a source we can check.”

The photograph beside the article showed a young woman holding a red and gold lantern. Under the photo, the caption read: “Margaret Hall, 19, helps Tom Barker organise Lantern Night.”

Josh moved closer. “Wait. Margaret Hall? That’s Gran. Hall was her surname before she married Grandad.”

“And the message says M,” Núria replied. “Tom planned to wait for Margaret at the bridge.”

They looked at each other. The facts became clearer, but they still had some questions. Did Margaret want to go? Did she arrive too late? Did she ever see Tom again?

“We shouldn’t decide what happened without asking her,” Josh said quietly. “It’s her story, not ours.”

“I agree,” said Núria. “We can wait until she’s ready to tell us.”

She carefully wrote the newspaper date, the journalist’s name and the photo caption in her notes, keeping clear facts apart from ideas. Then her face changed. “What if we bring Lantern Night back?” she asked.

Josh looked at her. “As in, really organise a whole festival?”

“Yes! Your school has a hall, the town has a square, and people still know the old bridge. We can make lanterns, invite families and bring the tradition back to life.”

“That’s a lot of work,” Josh said. “And it’s nearly November.”

“We have about six weeks. Enough time if we make arrangements.”

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"That's not the same as having enough time," Josh said, but he smiled now.

Núria thought about Gran walking through Ashby with her old lantern. The festival belonged to the whole town, not just one family.

Bringing it back wouldn't answer every question about 1974, but it might give people a reason to share their memories. They agreed to invite people of different ages to share memories and ideas. The festival would not just copy the past: new neighbours could contribute music, food and decorations. They still needed to check what was possible, but for the first time their idea seemed like a real project rather than a dream. Josh opened a new page.

At the top he wrote: "LANTERN NIGHT: CAN WE DO IT?"

"First problem," he said. "We need permission to use the bridge."

THINK ABOUT IT

Circle one answer for each question.

1 · DID YOU UNDERSTAND?

Which source gives the most reliable evidence?

- (A) An anonymous forum
- (B) A dated newspaper article with a journalist's name
- (C) A photo without a date

2 · WHAT HAPPENS NEXT? GUESS!

What permission will the group need?

- (A) Permission to use the old bridge
- (B) Permission to travel to Canada
- (C) Permission to change schools

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CHAPTER 4

Plan the day

Read it with Learning Path 4

WORDS TO HELP YOU

inclusive = *inclusiu*
heritage = *patrimoni*
responsible for = *responsable de*
battery lights = *llums amb piles*
permission = *permís*

On Monday morning Josh and Núria met Priya and Callum in the school dining room. Núria placed a notebook on the table and told them their plan. “We’re going to bring Lantern Night back on Saturday 12 December.”

Callum looked at the date. “Six weeks? I need six weeks just to finish a poster.”

“Then you’ll have to make an effort,” Priya replied. “I’ll draw up the timetable.”

They shared the work. Callum agreed to make posters for the school and the town square.

Priya agreed to organise the programme and ask her uncle’s band to play. Josh planned to meet Mr Davies, the head teacher, on Wednesday, while Núria wrote invitations and researched the old bridge. “We’ll have to make sure the festival is inclusive,” Núria said. “It’s a local tradition, but everybody should feel welcome, no matter what they usually celebrate.”

“We can invite families to share different autumn and winter traditions,” Priya suggested. “It doesn’t have to be a copy of 1974.”

They planned a free lantern workshop in the school hall, food stalls in the square, a parade and music at the bridge. They decided not to use real fire during the walk; battery lights were safer for a crowded event.

“It will probably rain,” Callum said. “Maybe we should call the event Umbrella Night.”

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“You can make that poster if it rains,” Josh said.

On Wednesday, Mr Davies listened carefully. He was very happy because Lantern Night was part of the town’s heritage. “The school hall is free on Saturday afternoon,” he said.

“You can use it for the workshop, and I’ll help you contact the community centre.” They agreed on a timetable.

At four, families are meeting in the hall to make lanterns. At half past five, the food stalls are opening in the square. At six, the parade is leaving for the old bridge, and at seven, the band is playing while people make wishes.

“We should also have a plan for bad weather,” Priya said. “The hall can stay open for anyone who doesn’t want to walk.”

But the old bridge was a bigger problem. It was closed after the storm in 1974, and the council was responsible for it.

“We can’t organise a parade over the bridge without permission,” Josh said. “What if it’s still not safe?”

“Then we’ll change the way,” Núria replied. “First we ask. We don’t want other people to be in danger.”

Núria offered to send a formal email. She remembered the words they practised in English lessons: “I am writing to propose…”, “We would like to…” and “Could we use…?” She wrote the request, but waited to check the timetable with the group. Before leaving school, the friends checked their jobs. Priya had the timetable, Callum had the posters, Josh talked to teachers, and Núria had the formal request.

Each person knew what to do next, and they agreed to check their progress together rather than leave the difficult work to one person. That evening Callum sent his poster. It had a dark sky, hundreds of small lights and a title that made everybody smile: “ASHBY LANTERN NIGHT IS BACK!” Josh printed it and put it on the kitchen table beside the fruit plate. When Gran came into the room, she noticed the poster immediately.

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She put on her glasses and read each word carefully. For a moment, nobody spoke. “I remember that bridge,” she said.

Her face changed when she read the festival’s name. Josh was about to explain, but Gran looked straight at him. “Who told you about Tom?” she asked.

Núria saw that their plan was also about Gran’s own life, not only a school activity. Some memories could make her sad.

Núria wanted to know how Gran would feel when she heard what they found.

THINK ABOUT IT

Circle one answer for each question.

1 · DID YOU UNDERSTAND?

What must they ask the council?

- (A) Money for fireworks
- (B) A new bus
- (C) Permission to use the bridge

2 · WHAT HAPPENS NEXT? GUESS!

What will Gran do after seeing the poster?

- (A) Tell the teenagers her story
- (B) Leave Ashby forever
- (C) Stop the school project immediately

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CHAPTER 5

Gran's story

Read it with Learning Path 5

WORDS TO HELP YOU

interfere = *ficar-se on no et demanen*
regret = *penedir-se*
eventually = *finalment*
request = *sol·licitud*
hesitated = *va dubtar*

When Gran read the poster, the kitchen went very quiet. Josh opened his mouth, but Núria spoke first. "We found an old lantern in the attic," she explained. "Then we went to the library and checked a newspaper article about Lantern Night. We're sorry if we made you sad. We didn't mean to interfere."

Gran sat down and placed the poster on the table. For a moment, she studied its colourful lights. "Tom Barker was the boy who lived next door," she began. "We used to walk to school together. We were always making plans for the festival. He had wonderful ideas, and I made sure those ideas became real."

"That sounds like us," Josh said to Núria.

Gran smiled. "Perhaps it does. I was nineteen and Tom was twenty-one. We were close friends, and slowly we became more than friends."

In 1974 Tom received a job offer from a school in Canada. He wanted Margaret to go with him.

It was an exciting opportunity, but she wasn't sure she could leave her family and the town she loved. They spent several weeks talking about the future without making a decision.

"Tom knew I loved Lantern Night," Gran continued. "So he wrote a message on my lantern. He planned to wait at the bridge on the evening of the festival. I could give him my answer there."

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“And then the storm came,” Josh said. “The weather was terrible. My father didn’t let me go out. When I got to the bridge, it was already closed because of the damage. Tom wasn’t there. The following week he went to Canada. We exchanged a few letters, but writing letters wasn’t easy, and in the end we stopped writing to each other.”

“Did you regret staying?” Núria asked carefully.

Gran thought before answering. “I missed Tom, of course. But later I met your grandad, and we made a happy life together. I wouldn’t change that. Life doesn’t give us only one possible happy ending.”

Josh looked at the lantern. “Then why did you keep it hidden?”

“Because I didn’t know how to explain all those feelings. The festival was part of my life when I was young. It was also important to my town. After it disappeared, the lantern reminded me of both wonderful and difficult things.”

Núria described the celebration they planned.

She said clearly that everybody could take part, that they checked the plans to keep people safe and that they wanted to remember the town’s history without telling everybody Gran’s own story. “Would you like to help us?” she asked.

“Yes,” Gran said. “I would appreciate the opportunity to see Lantern Night again.”

Later that evening Núria finished the email to Councillor Hughes.

She began formally: “I am writing to propose the return of Lantern Night, a local tradition which used to take place every autumn.” She described the free workshop, food stalls, music and parade on Saturday 12 December. She asked if the bridge could be used from six to eight and offered to send a plan to keep people safe. She closed with “I look forward to hearing from you” and “Kind regards”. She checked every detail before sending it.

She knew that a well-written request could make the difference between a lovely idea and a real event. At the same time, Josh searched for

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Tom Barker in Canada. There were many results, but one profile caught his attention: Tom Barker, a teacher who no longer worked in Toronto, aged seventy-three. The photograph showed an old man holding a red and gold lantern. Josh hesitated. He didn't want to surprise Gran and make her sad.

Then he decided to send a kind message and ask Tom if he would like to hear about the town festival, without making promises about Gran. He attached Callum's poster and typed: "Hello. My name is Josh Green. I think you knew my gran, Margaret Hall, many years ago…" He looked at the screen for a long time before he pressed send.

THINK ABOUT IT

Circle one answer for each question.

1 · DID YOU UNDERSTAND?

Why did Margaret miss Tom at the bridge?

- (A) She forgot the date
- (B) The storm and her father kept her home, and the bridge closed
- (C) Tom went to a different town

2 · WHAT HAPPENS NEXT? GUESS!

What will Tom do after Josh contacts him?

- (A) Delete the message
- (B) Send a photo of Australia
- (C) Come to Lantern Night

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CHAPTER 6

Lantern Night

Read it with the final product

WORDS TO HELP YOU

safety arrangements = *mesures de seguretat*
guided = *van guiar*
disbelief = *incredulitat*
volunteers = *voluntaris*
community = *comunitat*

Two important replies arrived the next week. Councillor Hughes wrote to Núria and said that the old bridge, fixed in 2009, could be used for the parade under the agreed safety arrangements. Tom Barker also answered Josh's message. Josh read the reply three times and called Tom privately to talk about the plan.

"You're smiling at your phone again," Núria said.

"I might know something you don't," Josh replied. "That is a dangerous thing to say to a person who finished a mystery."

On Saturday 12 December, thick fog was all over Ashby. Callum stood in the school hall and looked outside. "We're going to be the first people to organise a festival that nobody can see," he said.

"It's only morning," Priya replied.

"Give the weather a chance." By lunchtime, the fog began to disappear.

The group checked the timetable, checked the bridge arrangements and made sure there were volunteers to help the crowd. They chose safe little lights rather than real fire for the parade.

Everyone wanted the celebration to be beautiful, but also safe and welcoming. At four o'clock, the school hall was full of families. Some people remembered the old Lantern Night; others discovered it for the first time. Children made paper lanterns with coloured pictures. Priya's uncle's band played music, and the food tables gave people soup and seasonal food.

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Núria offered panellets, explaining how they are eaten during the Castanyada.

"They're disappearing faster than our tickets," Callum said.

"It's a free festival. We don't have tickets," Priya reminded him. "Exactly. And the panellets still disappear faster."

At half past five, people gathered in the town square. Families carried lanterns of all colours. Some were simple, some were beautiful, and one looked a little too much like a huge pumpkin. Gran arrived with her red and gold lantern from more than fifty years ago.

"Are you ready?" Josh asked.

"More than ready," she answered, but she looked nervous.

At six, the parade set off.

Lights moved slowly through the dark streets. Núria held up her phone so her family in Catalonia could watch for a moment. "Look, this is Lantern Night!" she said.

Her little brother was very happy: "It's like the Castanyada, but everybody has a lamp!" When the parade got to the old bridge, the volunteers helped the crowd find the safe place to walk. Gran stopped in the centre and looked towards the other side. A tall old man stood there with a lantern exactly like hers. "Hello, Margaret," the man said. "I'm sorry I'm late."

Gran looked at him in disbelief. "Tom Barker?"

"The same Tom. But I walk a little more slowly these days."

"Only fifty-two years late," she said. They laughed, and the people around them began to clap. Josh moved back, letting them decide how much of the moment they wanted to share. Gran and Tom talked quietly together.

The festival wasn't about showing everybody their own story; it was about giving the town its tradition back. Later, Núria lit the little light in her lantern and made a wish: that Lantern Night would be celebrated every year and would continue to welcome new neighbours. She looked

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around at the music, the food and the people who worked together. The old tradition found a new place in the community.

The next morning, the Ashby Herald printed a photograph under the title "LANTERN NIGHT RETURNS". The article explained the festival's history and said that the council, local volunteers and the school planned to hold it again next December. Josh showed Núria the newspaper. "So, are you coming back next year?"

"Yes," she said. "And next time I'm making twice as many panellets."

"Make three times as many," he replied. "I know our town."

THINK ABOUT IT

Circle one answer for each question.

1 · DID YOU UNDERSTAND?

Who appears at the old bridge?

- (A) Tom Barker with a lantern
- (B) A television presenter
- (C) The mayor in a witch costume

2 · WHAT HAPPENS NEXT? GUESS!

What does the town plan to do next December?

- (A) Close the bridge again
- (B) Celebrate Lantern Night again
- (C) Cancel all winter festivals

✦ ✦ ✦

The end

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